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ACTOR PART BOOK

# The Mother

*silence that finally screams*

*Six Characters in Search of an Author*

*Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore · Pirandello, trans. Storer 1922*

A Village Players production · Lausanne

Director: **Kiarash Jamshidi**

**36 SPEECHES · 695 WORDS ACROSS THE PLAY**

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## WHO THE MOTHER IS

**She is the fixed wound of the family, and the production's silent centre.** The division to hold, all evening, is this: the Father *explains* the wound, the Step-Daughter *exposes* it, the Son *refuses* it — and the Mother *carries* it. So she does not become cleverer than the others; she becomes more unavoidable. She is not in the argument. When the Father speaks we hear ideas; when the Step-Daughter speaks we hear revenge; when the Mother *moves*, we hear the cost. Her sorrow is active, never weak — she protects, she hides, she interrupts, she refuses to look, and then suddenly looks; she blocks her daughter from going too far; she tries to save the children, too late. Give her few words and a body that changes the temperature of the room: when she speaks, the room stops, no one jokes, and no one explains her away in the next breath. The **Child-bundle is her anchor** — when the men argue she checks it, when she is attacked she covers it, when the Son turns away she holds it lower as if it had grown heavier, and before the fountain she is the first to feel it gone. Score the role around the object, not around tears.

A woman in modest black under a heavy widow's veil. The veil is heavy enough that, lowered, it does her listening for her. It is lifted only once in the whole play — by the Father, in Act One, against her will; she never lifts it herself, not even at the fountain, where she goes to her son's body still behind it. The face beneath is the colour of wax. She is not crushed in the sentimental way; she is the weight of a thing that has been pressed down for so long it no longer has the muscle for its own posture. She has lost two children; one is the Child-bundle in her arms, the other is the Boy-chair leaning against her knee in Act Three, and she holds them both as if their staying still depended on the exact angle of her fingers. Her hands do most of her acting — when the Step-Daughter accuses, her grip on the Child-bundle tightens by one knuckle; when Madame Pace says *he pay cash*, the grip becomes a fist.

She has three silences, and they are not the same silence. The first is Act One — the silence of a woman who does not yet believe the room will hear her, and would not know what to say to it if it did. The second is the shop-scene silence — the silence of being made to watch her daughter's worst hour staged in front of her, ending the moment Madame Pace says *he clean, he polite, he pay cash*, when one whole act and a half of pressed-down speech finds a voice in one breath. The third is the silence of Act Three: the Child-bundle in her lap, the coat at her knee, the room arguing about whether what happened to her really happened. Three silences. Score them. Play them differently.

Her line *It's taking place now. It happens all the time* should land like a stone learning to speak. Four other lines are almost nothing on the page and must not be swallowed by the louder energy around her — *But you drove me away; My son —; Stop him; Not in front of her*. Each needs a half-second of its own air; they are the spine of her, and the production fails her if the Father's argument or the Step-Daughter's revenge rolls straight over them. Do not make her sympathetic in the easy way. She is heavier than that. When she cries out at the fountain — really cries out, at the very end — she will not need to project. The voice will do it on its own; it has been waiting the entire production to use itself.

## THE PLAY, AND HOW IT BEGINS

**What it is.** Pirandello's *Six Characters in Search of an Author* (1921). A theatre company's ordinary rehearsal is interrupted by six figures — a Father, a Mother, a Step-Daughter, a Son, and two silent children — who claim to be unfinished Characters, abandoned by their author, and demand that their drama be staged. The evening is the collision between their fixed, unbearable story and a working company's attempt to turn it into theatre.

**This production.** Set in Lausanne, played by **nine live performers** with **two stage objects** in place of the two youngest children (a coat-and-chair for the Boy, a wrapped bundle for the Child), on three stripped settings — **no projection, no screen**. One interval, after Act One; the second half plays unbroken to the fountain.

**How it opens.** The curtain is already up on a half-lit working stage. The Village Players are dragging themselves into a rehearsal of another Pirandello play, *Mixing It Up* — the Manager arrives tired and behind, there is the business of the cook's cap, the Players bicker. Then the working lights soften to a strange amber: the Door-keeper carries in the Boy-chair, and the four family Characters walk on, the Step-Daughter already holding the Child-bundle. From that entrance the play has begun, and it does not let go.

## HOW TO READ THIS BOOK

Everything this role says and does, in performance order, grouped by act and by part. Each speech is preceded by a short **CUE** — the tail of the line before it — so you can find your entrance. Where the role doubles a function, the function is printed beside the line (*as Prompter*, and so on); chorus lines the company speaks together keep their group tag (*All Three Players*). Blocking lives in the bracketed action cues inside the speeches. The text is pulled byte-for-byte from the Director's Copy, so it always matches the current script.

# Act One — The Family

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## PART I *The Rehearsal*

THE MOTHER DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

*THE MOTHER* seems crushed and terrified as if by an intolerable weight of shame and abasement. She is dressed in modest black and wears a thick widow's veil of crêpe. When she lifts this, she reveals a wax-like face. She always keeps her eyes downcast.

*THE SON* (22) tall, severe in his attitude of contempt for *THE FATHER*, supercilious and indifferent to *THE MOTHER*. He looks as if he had come on the stage against his will.

## PART II *The Interruption*

18 SPEECHES · 262 WORDS

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... are bastards. And he won't even recognise her as his mother. Wretch.

**THE MOTHER** [to the *MANAGER*; one arm tightens around the Child-bundle, the other goes toward the Boy-chair as if to keep both of them upright]. In the name of these two little children, I beg you... [She grows faint and is about to fall.] Oh God!

**CUE** *The Father:* Look at her! Look at her!

**THE MOTHER.** No, no; stop it please!

**CUE** *The Father:* Let them see you!

**THE MOTHER** [rising and covering her face with her hands]. I beg you, sir. Stop him. I cannot bear what he wants to do.

**CUE** *The Father:* ... this: she has had a lover, a man who should be here.

**THE MOTHER** [the cry surprising her — a hand goes to her own mouth, as if to catch it]. No! No!

**CUE** *The Father:* ... lies all in these four children she has had by two men.

**THE MOTHER.** I had them? Have you got the courage to say that I *wanted* them? [To the *COMPANY*.] It was him. He gave me to that other man. He made me go.

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* It isn't true.

**THE MOTHER** [her hand tightens on the Child-bundle without her noticing]. Not true? And what can you know about it?

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... two years old, it was because this man forced her to it.

**THE MOTHER** [voice tight; eyes still on the floor]. He forced me to it. [Silence. No one fills it. For the first time she raises her eyes — to the *SON*. He does not look back. She lowers them again.] And I call God to witness it. [To the *MANAGER*, still without lifting her head.] Ask him [Indicates the *FATHER*.] if it isn't true. Let him speak. You [To the *STEP-DAUGHTER*.] are not in a position to know anything about it.

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... and happiness with my father while he lived. Can you deny it?

**THE MOTHER.** No, I don't deny it...

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... true, isn't it? Tell them! Why don't you speak, you little fool?

**THE MOTHER.** Leave him alone. Why do you want to make me appear ungrateful, daughter? I don't want to offend your father. I have told him: I did not leave my house and my son through any fault of mine. Not from any wilful passion.

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* It was a near thing, though, you know!

**THE MOTHER** *[low, not raised; she turns the Child-bundle's face into her shoulder before she speaks — the words are for the bundle, not the room].* Shame, my daughter. *[A breath. The STEP-DAUGHTER's laugh is still in the air.]* Not in front of her.

**CUE** *The Father:* ... one thing, she hears another — and the explanation becomes another crime.

**THE MOTHER** *[not loud, not an accusation — the plain fact, set down in the middle of the room].* But you drove me away. *[A beat. It lands before he can talk over it.]*

**CUE** *The Father:* Do you hear her? I drove her away! She truly believes it.

**THE MOTHER** *[looking at the floor between them].* You know how to talk, and I don't. But believe me, sir *[To MANAGER.]* — after he had married me... who knows why?... I was a poor woman. Nothing.

**CUE** *The Father:* ... a master. Like an animal one has taken in out of pity.

**THE MOTHER.** Ah yes...

**CUE** *The Father:* It's true about the son anyway, isn't it?

**THE MOTHER.** He took my son away from me first of all.

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... stepdaughter in the back of a dressmaker's shop. He calls it pity.

**THE MOTHER.** And so he turned me out —.

**CUE** *The Father:* ... her to that man, gentlemen... to let her go free of me.

**THE MOTHER.** And to free himself.

**CUE** *The Father:* ... her daughter write — to tell me that they were in need.

**THE MOTHER.** And how was I to divine all this sentiment in him — after so many years apart, and all that had happened...

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... us — well, the rest of us serve a rather different purpose.

**THE MOTHER.** You will believe me, gentlemen, that it never entered my mind that the old hag offered me work because she had her eye on my daughter.

### **PART III** *The Bargain*

THE MOTHER DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

# Act Two — The Theatre

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## PART I *The Setup*

2 SPEECHES · 34 WORDS

**CUE** *The Son:* ... this is fine. Fine. And to think I can't even get away.

**THE MOTHER.** Isn't my punishment the worst of all? [*Then seeing from the SON's manner that he will not bother himself about her.*] My God. Why are you so cruel? Isn't it enough for one person to carry all this? Must you make others see it too?

*The MOTHER rises. She takes one step toward the SON, the Child-bundle still in her arms.*

**CUE** *The Mother:* ... person to carry all this? Must you make others see it too?

**THE MOTHER** [*barely*]. My son —

*The MOTHER hides her face in her hands. From the dressing-rooms and the little door at the back of the stage the ACTORS and STAGE MANAGER return, followed by the PROPERTY MAN, and the PROMPTER. At the same moment, THE MANAGER comes out of his office, accompanied by the FATHER and the STEP-DAUGHTER.*

## PART II *The Apparition*

4 SPEECHES · 190 WORDS

**CUE** *Madame Pace:* ... ruin in Pace's shop. The lady know. The lady stay quiet too.

**THE MOTHER** [*jumping up amid the amazement and consternation of the actors who had not been noticing her. They move to restrain her — and the voice that comes out of her is the one she has not used for years, and once it starts it comes out faster than her body can carry it*]. You old devil! You murderess! [*Trembling, but the voice does not stop.*] Three years you took her from me. Three years. I sat at your kitchen table with the needle in my hand, and the tea you served me — your kind tea, your terrible kind tea — and somewhere I knew. Somewhere, in the back of my head, I half-knew. But if I let myself know it, the children at home did not eat. So I drank the tea. I drank your tea, madame, every Wednesday, every Friday, sometimes the Sunday — and I did not let myself see that my own daughter was just down the corridor in your back room. [*Her hand, briefly, at her own chest.*] May God forgive me. May God forgive me. I drank the tea.

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* Calm yourself, Mother, calm yourself! Please don't...

**THE MOTHER** [*she cannot quite stop yet; the voice has been waiting too long*]. And the smile, devil. The smile you had for me when I came into the kitchen with the finished sewing. I thought it was a kindness. I thought you were the only person in Lausanne with a kindness in her for a poor widow from another town. May God forgive me — I thought it was a kindness.

**CUE** *The Father:* Calm yourself! Don't get excited! Sit down now!

**THE MOTHER** [*the voice short again now, as if she has spent what she had*]. Well then. Take that woman out of my sight.

The **MOTHER**, who watches the progress of the scene with **THE SON** beside her, the Child-bundle held tight in her arms and the Boy-chair pulled in against her knee, is on thorns; and follows with varying expressions of sorrow, indignation, anxiety, and horror the words and actions of the other two. From time to time she hides her face in her hands and sobs.

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter*: No sir... I'll do it myself.

**THE MOTHER** *[without lifting her head from her hands]*. Oh, my God. My God.

### PART III *The Substitution*

4 SPEECHES · 107 WORDS

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter*: Well then, ask that Mother there to leave us.

**THE MOTHER** *[changing her low plaint into a sharp cry]*. No! No! Don't permit it, sir, don't permit it!

**CUE** *The Manager*: But it's only to try it.

**THE MOTHER** *[to the Child-bundle, not to the room]*. I can't bear it. I can't.

**CUE** *The Manager*: But since it has happened already... I don't understand!

**THE MOTHER** *[the Child-bundle in one arm, the other hand on the Boy-chair — both children held at once; she does not move from her chair for the whole speech]*. It's taking place now. It happens all the time. My torment isn't a pretended one. I live and feel every minute of my torture. Those two children there — have you heard them speak? They can't speak any more. They cling to me to keep my torment actual and vivid. But for themselves, they do not exist. They aren't any more. And she *[Indicating the Step-Daughter.]* has run away, she has left me, and is lost.

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter*: ... against his breast. Cry out, mother. Cry out as you did then!

**THE MOTHER** *[coming forward to separate them]*. No! My daughter, my daughter! *[And after having pulled her away from him.]* You brute! you brute! She is my daughter! Don't you see she's my daughter?

# Act Three — The Question

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## PART I *The Trap*

2 SPEECHES · 28 WORDS

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... clear, at any rate, that it is in spite of my wishes.

**THE MOTHER** *[from her corner; the head shakes by itself, slowly, twice].* For all the good that's come of it...

**CUE** *The Manager:* I understand! Good Heavens! I understand! I'm taking it into account.

**THE MOTHER** *[the Child-bundle held high against her chest so that her own face is half-hidden by it].* I beg you, sir, to let it appear quite plain that for conscience' sake I did try in every way...

## PART II *The Refusal*

THE MOTHER DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

*The MOTHER gets up alarmed and terrified at the thought that he is really about to go away. Instinctively she lifts her arms to prevent him, without, however, leaving her seat.*

## PART III *The Fountain*

6 SPEECHES · 74 WORDS

**CUE** *The Son:* ... was no scene between me and her. Ask her how it was!

**THE MOTHER.** Yes, it's true. I had come into his room...

**CUE** *The Manager:* ... And let me hear your mother! You were saying you had entered...

**THE MOTHER.** Yes. Into his room. I couldn't bear it any more. I went to tell him what I have inside me. All of it. *[A hand at her chest, briefly.]* But the moment he saw me...

**CUE** *The Son:* ... no scene. I went away, that's all! I don't care for scenes!

**THE MOTHER.** It's true, true. That's how it was.

**CUE** *The Manager:* ... we've got to do this bit between you and him. It's indispensable.

**THE MOTHER.** I'm ready. Whenever you are. If you could just find a moment for me to tell him what I have, here. *[Her hand at her chest.]*

*The MOTHER, frightened, tries to separate them.*

**CUE** *The Son:* No! No! And for God's sake stop it, or else...

**THE MOTHER** *[both hands out, trying to part them].* Please! please!

*The MOTHER does not cry out at once. She goes first to the basin and reaches down for the CHILD-BUNDLE in the water; then, hearing the PLAYERS take up the BOY-CHAIR behind her, she turns and reaches for that too. Her arms*



cannot hold both. The veil stays down over her face — she never lifts it herself, not even now. Only then does the sound come out of her.

**CUE** *The Son:* ... will never forget. Watching his little sister, there in the water. Then...

**THE MOTHER.** My son! My son! *[Then amid the cries and exclamations one hears her voice.]* Help! Help!

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*Village Players · Lausanne · The Mother part book · lines and actions pulled from the Director's Copy.*